THE CRITICAL READER

e-guide

Complete SAT® & ACT® Grammar Rules

- For SAT Writing and ACT English
- Detailed explanations & examples
- Separate section for ACT-only rules

20 key concepts!

Covers the Digital SAT

Erica L. Meltzer

author of *The Ultimate Guide to SAT Grammar*

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1. PERIODS & SEMICOLONS

Semicolon = Period

On the SAT and ACT, these two types of punctuation are considered identical, and all other things being equal, you will never be asked to choose between them.

Semicolons and periods are used:

A. Between two complete sentences

Correct: London is an old **city. It** has been inhabited for around 2,000 years.

Correct: London is an old **city; it** has many new buildings.

B. Before conjunctive adverbs such as *however*, *therefore*, or *moreover* at the beginning (first word) of a clause.

Correct: London is an old **city; however,** it has many new buildings.

Correct: London is an old **city; therefore,** it has buildings from many different eras.

Note: ACT grammar questions testing however use a semicolon in the correct version, whereas rhetoric questions use a period.

Important: Make sure to read through every sentence all the way through to the period. Otherwise, you might not notice when there are two sentences.

In particular, watch out for "sentence boundary" questions, in which the beginning of one sentence appears to be part of the previous sentence. If you don't read far enough, you might think the sentence is fine as is.

Incorrect: Barbara McClintock is a scientist whose discovery of "jumping" genes helped earn her the Nobel **Prize in 1983,** she won the award in Physiology or Medicine.

Correct: Barbara McClintock is a scientist whose discovery of "jumping" genes helped earn her the Nobel **Prize. In 1983,** she won the award in Physiology or Medicine.

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2. COLONS & DASHES

Colons and single dashes are used to introduce lists and explanations. The SAT and ACT consider these types of punctuation grammatically identical and will never ask you to choose between them. Colons, however, tend to be tested more frequently.

Unlike a semicolon, a colon or a dash can be followed by either a full sentence or a fragment. (Stylistically, a dash creates a stronger, more dramatic break, but you do not need to worry about that for testing purposes.)

A colon or dash must always follow a full sentence that makes sense as a complete thought and logically sets up the information that follows.

For example, *they made* is a complete sentence, but it cannot stand by itself.

In contrast, *they made an important discovery* makes sense as a statement on its own.

A. Before a list

Incorrect: London is home to a variety **of:** museums, castles, and shops.

Incorrect: London is home to a wide variety of attractions including/such **as: museums,** castles, and shops.

Correct: Visitors to London often spend their time in three main types of **attractions:** museums, castles, and shops.

Correct: Visitors to London often spend their time in three main types of **attractions—** museums, castles, and shops.

B. Before an explanation

Correct: When the Manchus took control of China, the Great Wall lost its protective **purpose: the** Chinese empire now extended well north of the wall, and its new enemies came from across the sea.

Correct: When the Manchus took control of China, the Great Wall lost its protective **purpose—the** Chinese empire now extended well north of the wall, and its new enemies came from across the sea.

In the example above, the second clause explains why the Great Wall ceased to have military significance. As a result, the colon or dash is acceptable.

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Important: Note that when a colon or dash separates two sentences, as is common in explanations, it is grammatically identical to a period or semicolon.

In particular, watch out for colons on SAT questions requiring you to separate two sentences. Correct answers frequently involve colons (a period or semicolon option does not appear), presumably because fewer students know how to use this type of punctuation.

3. COMMA + FANBOYS

FANBOYS (Coordinating Conjunction): For, And, Nor, But, Or, Yet, So

A. Comma + FANBOYS = Period = Semicolon

And & but are the two most popular conjunctions; so & yet are tested infrequently; and or & nor are almost never tested.

Correct: London is a very old **city, but** some parts of it are extremely modern.

Correct: London is a very old **city, and** it is very appealing to tourists.

B. Comma Splices

When two sentences are joined by a comma, the result is known as a comma splice. Comma splices are always incorrect.

Tip-off: comma + pronoun (e.g., *it, they*, *s/he*, *one, you*, *I*)

Incorrect: London is a very old **city, it** has some extremely modern parts.

Correct: London is a very old **city. It** has some extremely modern parts.

Correct: London is a very old **city; it** has some extremely modern parts.

Incorrect: London and Paris are two of the world's most popular **cities, they** are visited by millions of tourists every year.

Correct: London and Paris are two of the world's most popular **cities. They** are visited by millions of tourists every year.

Correct: London and Paris are two of the world's most popular **cities; they** are visited by millions of tourists every year.

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C. Comma + FANBOYS + Verb = WRONG

When two clauses in a row have the same subject, but the subject does not appear in the second clause, no comma is used before a FANBOYS conjunction.

Shortcut: comma + and/but = period, so plug in a period in place of comma + and/but.

Incorrect: London is a very old **city, but has** many modern buildings.

Plug in: London is a very old **city. Has many** modern buildings.

Correct: London is a very old **city but has many** modern buildings.

4. COMMAS & DEPENDENT CLAUSES

Dependent clauses (fragments) cannot stand on their own as complete sentences.

They begin with subordinating conjunctions, e.g., ***although***, ***because***, ***when***, ***until***, ***while***, ***since***, ***before***, and ***after***.

- Because the plant requires sunlight
- When the exhibit opened
- After the book was published

A dependent clause can be placed either before or after an independent clause to form a sentence. When the dependent clause comes first, it must be followed by a comma.

Incorrect: Because London is a very old **city it** has buildings from many different eras.

Correct: Because London is a very old **city, it** has buildings from many different eras.

Incorrect: Although London is a very old **city it** has many modern buildings.

Correct: Although London is a very old **city, it** has many modern buildings.

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5. TRANSITIONAL WORDS & PHRASES (MEANING)

Many questions on the ACT and (especially) the SAT also test transitional words and phrases in terms of meaning. In such cases, all of the answers will be grammatically correct, and the correct choice will create the most logical meaning. There are three main types of transitions.

Continuers, e.g., *in addition*, *moreover*, *in fact*, *for example*, and *then*, add new and **similar** ideas, **emphasize** previous ideas, and convey **sequence** of events.

Cause-and-effect words, e.g., *therefore*, *consequently*, and *thus*, indicate that an action or event is the **result** of a previous action/event.

Contradictors, e.g., *however*, *nevertheless*, and *in contrast*, signal **opposing** ideas.

Whenever you encounter a transition question, cross out or ignore the transition and state the relationship between the sentences (similar, opposite, cause-and-effect) before checking the answers.

The obvious reason for the construction of the Great Wall of China was **protection**.
_____ China had **no powerful enemies** when the Wall began to be built.

The two halves of the sentence express opposing ideas, so a contradictor is needed.

Correct: The obvious reason for the construction of the Great Wall of China was **protection**.
However, China had **no powerful enemies** when the Wall began to be built.

Important: when two transitions have the exact same meaning (e.g., *therefore*/*consequently*), both can automatically be eliminated because no question can have more than one right answer. Note, however, that this shortcut is generally more applicable to the ACT than the SAT.

In addition, if there is an OMIT/DELETE option on the ACT, or an option without a transition, check it first because it will usually be correct.

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6. NON-ESSENTIAL INFORMATION

Non-essential information (clause, phrase, or word) can be removed from a sentence without affecting its essential meaning. It's like a little interruption. When the information between the commas is crossed out, the sentence still makes sense.

Non-essential information can be punctuated in three different ways:

- **2 Commas**
- **2 Dashes**
- **2 Parentheses**

Note that only one type of punctuation can be used—the options above **cannot be mixed and matched**. On the SAT and ACT, many incorrect answers involve this error.

A. Two Commas

Commas are the punctuation type most often used to mark non-essential clauses: one must be placed at the beginning, and one at the end.

Incorrect: London **which is a very old city,** has some extremely modern parts.

Incorrect: London**, which is a very old city has** some extremely modern parts.

Incorrect: London**—which is a very** old **city,** has some extremely modern parts.

Correct: London**, which is a very old city,** has some extremely modern parts.
(London … has some extremely modern parts.)

Single words, generally transitions such as however and though, can be used non-essentially.

Incorrect: London is a very old city. It does**, however** have some modern parts.

Incorrect: London is a very old city. It does **however,** have some modern parts.

Correct: London is a very old city. It does**, however,** have some modern parts.

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B. Two Dashes

Grammatically, dashes are identical to commas when used to set off non-essential information.

Correct: London**—which is a very old city—**has some modern parts.

The one **exception** involves non-essential words, which can be set off by commas only.

Incorrect: London is a very old city. It does**—however—**have some modern parts.

Correct: London is a very old city. It does**, however,** have some modern parts.

C. Two Parentheses

Parentheses can also be used to indicate non-essential phrases and clauses. (In fact, these elements are also sometimes referred to as "parenthetical" information).

Correct: London **(which is a very old city)** has some modern parts.

The main challenge with parentheses involves the unnecessary use of commas.

A comma before an open parenthesis is always incorrect.

Incorrect: London**, (which is a very old city)** has some modern parts.

A comma before a close parenthesis is almost always wrong as well.

Incorrect: London **(which is a very old city),** has some modern parts.

However, in some rare instances, a comma may be required after a close parenthesis for an unrelated reason, e.g., to set off FANBOYS + following sentence.

Correct: London has been inhabited continuously since Roman times **(47 A.D., to be exact),** but it has some very modern parts.

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7. COMMAS WITH NAMES & TITLES

The use of commas around names and titles is frequently tested on both the SAT and ACT. These questions test whether the name or title in question is essential or non-essential.

In general, there are only two correct options:

- **No commas (essential)**
- **Two commas, one before and one after (non-essential)**

When a name/title appears in the middle of a sentence, a single comma before the name or title is incorrect. Answers with this construction can be eliminated automatically.

To determine whether commas are necessary, read the sentence without the name/title, and see if it still makes basic grammatical sense.

Incorrect: Researchers led by **engineering professor, Vikram Iyer,** have created a set of robotic devices that can change shape in mid-air.

Cross out: Researchers led by engineering professor…have created a set of robotic devices that can change shape in mid-air.

This does not make sense, so the name is essential. No commas are needed.

Correct: Researchers led by **engineering professor Vikram Iyer** have created a set of robotic devices that can change shape in mid-air.

On the other hand:

Incorrect: Researchers led by **a University of Washington engineering professor Vikram Iyer** have created a set of robotic devices that can change shape in mid-air.

Cross out: Researchers led by **a University of Washington engineering professor**…have created a set of robotic devices that can change shape in mid-air.

The above sentence does make sense when the name is removed, so two commas are needed.

In rare instances, a comma may be required after a name/title for a separate reason, e.g., to mark a new clause.

Correct: Led by **engineering professor Vikram Iyer,** researchers at the University of Washington have created a set of robotic devices that can change shape in mid-air.

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8. ADDITIONAL COMMA USES & MISUSES

Commas SHOULD be used:

A. To separate items in a list

Incorrect: Building muscle can boost **metabolism aid weight loss and** increase endurance.

Correct: Building muscle can boost **metabolism, aid weight loss, and** increase endurance.

Note: the comma before *and* + final item is optional and is not tested on the SAT or ACT.

B. To separate adjectives whose order could be reversed, or separated by *and*.

Incorrect: Dinosaurs may have been **active warm-blooded** animals.

Correct: Dinosaurs may have been **active, warm-blooded** animals.
(You could also say **active and warm-blooded**, or **warm-blooded, active**)

Note: Commas should also be used after introductory words or phrases (e.g., *however*, *in the beginning*, *in fact*), but this usage is not normally tested.

Commas should NOT be used:

A. Before or after a preposition (frequently tested)

Most common prepositions: *of*, *to*, *by*, *from*, *for*, *about*, *with*, *in*, *on*, *at*

Incorrect: Frida Kahlo is among the most famous **artists, of** the twentieth century.

Incorrect: Frida Kahlo is among the most famous **artists of,** the twentieth century.

Correct: Frida Kahlo is among the most famous **artists of** the twentieth century.

B. Between subjects and verbs

This rule holds true even when the subject is very long.

Incorrect: **<u>The oldest surviving bridge in London</u>, is** Richmond Bridge, completed in 1777.

Correct: **<u>The oldest surviving bridge in London</u> is** Richmond Bridge, completed in 1777.

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C. Between compound items (nouns, verbs, adjectives, etc. linked by and)

Shortcut: comma + *and* = period, so fill in a period and check whether there are two sentences.

Incorrect: Many tourists travel to **London, and Paris** to visit museums, and monuments.

Plug in: Many tourists travel to **London. Paris** to visit museums, and monuments.

Correct: Many tourists travel to **London and Paris** to visit museums and monuments.

D. Before or after the word *that*

Incorrect: London is a **city, that** has many old buildings and monuments.

Incorrect: London is a city **that, has** many old buildings and monuments.

Correct: London is a **city that** has many old buildings and monuments.

No *that* = no comma: A comma should also not be used when that is optional and does not appear. This construction is tested regularly on the ACT.

Incorrect: **The snow, used** to build an igloo must have enough strength to be cut and stacked correctly.

Correct: **The snow used (= the snow that is used)** to build an igloo must have enough strength to be cut and stacked correctly.

E. Between two adjectives whose order cannot be reversed

Incorrect: The Caribbean Sea contains some of the world's most **stunning, coral** reefs. (You cannot say "most coral and stunning reefs")

Correct: The Caribbean Sea contains some of the world's most **stunning coral** reefs.

F. Between adjectives and nouns

Incorrect: The Caribbean Sea contains some of the world's most **stunning, reefs**.

Correct: The Caribbean Sea contains some of the world's most **stunning reefs**.

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9. APOSTROPHES

A. Nouns

Apostrophe = Possessive, singular and plural
No apostrophe = Not possessive, plural only

To form possessives:

Singular nouns: add apostrophe + *-s*.

- The cell's DNA = the DNA in the cell
- The dress's buttons = the buttons on the dress
- The person's response = the response given by the person

Regular plural nouns: add *–s* or *-es* + apostrophe.

- The cells' DNA = the DNA in the cells
- The dresses' buttons = the buttons on the dresses

Irregular plural nouns (do not end in *-s*): add *apostrophe* + *-s*.

- The people's responses = the responses given by the people

Tip: when apostrophes are tested with two consecutive nouns, **the correct answer usually follows the pattern apostrophe-no apostrophe (noun's noun, or nouns' noun)** because the first noun must be possessing the second.

B. Pronouns

Pronouns are the opposite of nouns: no apostrophe = possessive

<u>It's vs. Its</u>

It's = it is
Its = possessive form of it
Its' & its's = do not exist

Important: when the ACT tests *it's vs. its*, the answer is almost always *its* because the test-writers know that many students associate apostrophes with the possessive.

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Incorrect: London is a city known for **it's (= it is)** many tourist attractions.

Correct: London is a city known for **its** many tourist attractions.

Incorrect: London is a popular destination; in fact, **its** among the world's most visited cities.

Correct: London is a popular destination; in fact, **it's (= it is)** among the world's most visited cities.

They're vs. Their vs. There

They're = they are
Their = possessive form of they; plural of its
There = a place

They're

Correct: London and Paris are two of the most famous cities and Europe, and **they're (= they are)** known for having many tourist attractions.

Their

Correct: London and Paris, two of the most famous cities in Europe, are known for **their** many tourist attractions.

There

Correct: In the nineteenth century, Paris was considered the capital of the art world because so many famous painters lived and worked **there**.

Who's vs. Whose (Primarily ACT)

Who's = Who is

Correct: Barbara McClintock is a scientist **who's (= who is)** best known for her discovery of "jumping" genes.

Whose = Possessive of *who*

Correct: Barbara McClintock is a scientist **whose** discovery of "jumping" genes helped earn her the 1983 Nobel Prize in Physiology or Medicine.

Note that whose, unlike who, can be used for both people and things/places.

Correct: London is a city **whose** museums, palaces, and shops make it a popular destination.

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10. PRONOUNS & NOUNS

A. Singular-Plural Agreement: Pronouns

Pronouns are words that replace and refer back to nouns.

- **Singular people = he or she** (Note: the SAT and ACT do not use the singular *they*)
- **Singular things = it, its, itself**
- **Plural = they, them, their, themselves**

The noun to which a pronoun refers (antecedent or referent) may not appear in the same sentence.

Incorrect: Painter Frida Kahlo (1907-1954) was best known for her **portraits. It was** strongly influenced by indigenous Mexican culture, as revealed by her use of bright colors and dramatic symbolism.

Correct: Painter Frida Kahlo (1907-1954) was best known for her **portraits. They were** strongly influenced by indigenous Mexican culture, as revealed by her use of bright colors and dramatic symbolism.

Pronoun agreement and apostrophes are often tested at the same time.

SAT:

Speed bumps are used in many countries around the world; _____ found most frequently in places where speed limits are legally imposed.

A) its
B) it's
C) they're
D) their

ACT:

Speed bumps are used in many countries around the world; its found most frequently in places where speed limits are legally imposed.

A. NO CHANGE
B. it's
C. they're
D. their

Because the referent speed bumps is plural, the plural pronoun *they* is required.

In addition, you would say *they are found*, so *they're* is the correct form.

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B. Singular-Plural Agreement: Nouns

Incorrect: The Kora, the balafon, and the ngoni are **an example** of African instruments that have strongly influenced certain types of rap music.

Correct: The Kora, the balafon, and the ngoni are **examples** of African instruments that have strongly influenced certain types of rap music.

C. People vs. Things

Who(m) = people

Which = things

Incorrect: Frida Kahlo was an artist **which gained** renown for her portraits.

Correct: Frida Kahlo was an artist **who gained** renown for her portraits.

D. Who vs. Whom

Whom before a verb = wrong

Incorrect: Frida Kahlo was an artist whom gained renown for her portraits.

Correct: Frida Kahlo was an artist who gained renown for her portraits.

Whom after a preposition = right

Incorrect: Frida Kahlo is a painter **to who** many artists owe their inspiration.

Correct: Frida Kahlo is a painter **to whom** many artists owe their inspiration.

Note: A verb can be placed after a phrase with pronoun + *whom*, e.g., *many of whom believe*.

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11. SUBJECT-VERB AGREEMENT

Forming verbs:

- **Singular 3rd person verbs end in -s, e.g., *it works***
- **Plural 3rd person verbs do not end in -s, e.g., *they work***

Most common irregular verb = to be

Singular: *is* (pres.), *was* (past)

Plural: *are* (pres.), *were* (past)

Tip: If you're unsure of a subject, check the beginning of the clause in which the verb appears.

A. Compound subject (noun and noun) = Plural

Incorrect: The highly textured bark and distinctive silhouette of the Dutch Elm tree **distinguishes** it from the equally common English Elm tree.

Correct: The highly textured bark and distinctive silhouette of the Dutch Elm tree **distinguish** it from the equally common English Elm tree.

B. Prepositional Phrase

Prepositional phrases begin with prepositions, e.g., *of*, *with*, *at*, *by*, *to*, *in*, *on*, *for*, *from*, and are often placed between subjects and verbs to distract from disagreements.

Incorrect: Illegal **logging** in Mexican forests **have** resulted in the destruction of the monarch butterfly's habitat.

Correct: Illegal **logging** in Mexican forests **has** resulted in the destruction of the monarch butterfly's habitat.

Also be on the lookout for compound subjects—two singular subjects connected by *and*.

Incorrect: **The Monarch and the Red Admiral** **is** among the most common butterfly species in North America.

Correct: **The Monarch and the Red Admiral** **are** among the most common butterfly species in North America.

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C. Non-Essential Clause

Non-essential clauses can also be placed between subjects and verbs to distract from errors.

Incorrect: **The cochineal**, a small insect "discovered" by Hernán Cortés in present-day Mexico, **were** commonly used as a colorant in painting, sculpture, furniture and textiles from the mid-sixteenth through the mid-nineteenth century.

Correct: **The cochineal**, a small insect "discovered" by Hernán Cortés in present-day Mexico, **was** commonly used as a colorant in painting, sculpture, furniture and textiles from the mid-sixteenth through the mid-nineteenth century.

D. Each and Every = Singular

Incorrect: **Each** of the chiefdoms to which the members of the Taino tribe belonged **were** ruled by a leader known as a cacique.

Correct: **Each** of the chiefdoms to which the members of the Taino tribe belonged **was** ruled by a leader known as a cacique.

Other subject-verb agreement errors to know:

- Collective nouns (group, country, school, team, board, government, etc.) = singular.
- There is = followed by singular noun; There are = followed by plural noun.
- In very rare instances, the verb may be placed before the subject, making errors difficult to hear, e.g., *In the nucleus of an atom* ***sit (pl.)*** ***elementary particles such as protons and neutrons***.

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12. VERB TENSE

A. Tense Consistency

Always keep verb tense consistent with that of other verbs in the paragraph. Paragraphs in the present should stay in the present; paragraphs in the past should stay in the past.

Start by checking the tense of the verbs in the sentence in question, as well as the surrounding sentences (before/after). The underlined verb must match the other verbs.

Incorrect: Painter Frida Kahlo (1907-1954) **earned** renown for her portraits. She **is** strongly influenced by indigenous Mexican culture, as revealed by her use of bright colors and dramatic symbolism. In her paintings, she **combined** elements of the classic Mexican tradition with modern surrealist techniques.

Correct: Painter Frida Kahlo (1907-1954) **earned** renown for her portraits. She **was** strongly influenced by indigenous Mexican culture, as revealed by her use of bright colors and dramatic symbolism. In her paintings, she **combined** elements of the classic Mexican tradition with modern surrealist techniques.

Important: Correct answers are usually in the simple past (*was*, *did*, *found*) or the present. Answers with more complex tenses (would have done, will have gone) are virtually always wrong.

B. Present Perfect – *has* / *have* + verb

Indicates an action beginning and the past and continuing into the present.

Tip-offs: *for* and *since*.

Incorrect: London and Paris **are** tourist attractions **for** hundreds of years.

Incorrect: London and Paris **are** tourist attractions **since** the eighteenth century.

Correct: London and Paris **have been** tourist attractions **for** hundreds of years

Correct: London and Paris **have been** tourist attractions **since** the eighteenth century.

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C**. Simple Past – one-word past form**

Describes a completed past action.

Incorrect: Rachel Carson **has published** *Silent Spring*, her groundbreaking book on environmental science, in 1962.

Correct: Rachel Carson **published** *Silent Spring*, her groundbreaking book on environmental science, in 1962.

The sentence describes a completed action that occurred in the past—the book's publication occurred in 1962 only.

D. Past Perfect – *had* + verb

When a sentence describes two completed actions in the past, the past perfect can be used to describe the action that came first.

Most of the time, either the simple past or the past perfect can be used, e.g., *Before Mae Jemison became an astronaut, she* ***studied / had studied*** *science for many years*. When this is the case, you will not be asked to choose between the simple past and past perfect.

When the phrase ***by the time*** appears, however, the past perfect must be used.

Incorrect: By the time Mae Jemison became an astronaut, she **studied** science for many years.

Correct: By the time Mae Jemison became an astronaut, she **had studied** science for many years.

E. Passive Voice

In the passive voice, the subject and object are flipped so that *x did y* becomes *y* ***was done by*** *x*.

In many cases, this form is associated with incorrect answer choices because it creates sentences that are wordy and awkward.

Incorrect: Many people who seriously consider pursuing a career in politics decide against doing so because **concerns are had by them** about maintaining their privacy.

Correct: Many people who seriously consider pursuing a career in politics decide against doing so because **they are concerned** about maintaining their privacy.

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In some instances, however, the passive voice may be required in order to create a grammatically correct construction (and no acceptable active answer choice will be provided).

Incorrect: The novel *Things Fall Apart* depicts the life of Okonkwo, a leader and wrestling champion in a fictional Nigerian village **that inhabited** by the Igbo people.

Correct: The novel *Things Fall Apart* depicts the life of Okonkwo, a leader and wrestling champion in a fictional Nigerian village that is inhabited by the Igbo people.

F. TO vs. -ING

You may also be asked to identify whether the TO (infinitive) or -ING (gerund) form of a verb is appropriate in a given situation. There is no rule; these questions must be answered by ear.

Incorrect: In an effort to attract new patrons, some museums are attempting implementing an approach known as "visitor engagement."

Correct: In an effort to attract new patrons, some museums are attempting to implement an approach known as "visitor engagement."

Note that on the SAT and ACT, subject-verb agreement questions commonly "pose" as tense questions. That is, they contain answer choices in different **tenses**, but only one option is correct in terms of **number**.

SAT:

Modern conceptions of the Vikings as either violent brutes or intrepid adventurers owe much to the Viking myths that _____ since the early twentieth century.

A) has predominated
B) have predominated
C) predominates
D) is predominating

ACT:

Modern conceptions of the Vikings as either violent brutes or intrepid adventurers owe much to the Viking myths that <u>has predominated</u> since the early twentieth century.

A. NO CHANGE
B. have predominated
C. predominates
D. is predominating

The presence of different tenses is just a distraction here; the subject of the verb in question is *myths*, plural, and B is the only choice that contains a plural verb (*have*). As a result, it is the only possible answer.

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13. PARALLEL STRUCTURE & WORD PAIRS

A. Lists (3 Items or More)

Keep all list items parallel: noun, noun, and noun; -ING, -ING, or -ING; verb, verb, and verb.

Incorrect: Deception expert Pamela Meyer has worked with a team of researchers to analyze studies on lying from scholars, police officers, and **working as psychologists**.

Correct: Deception expert Pamela Meyer has collaborated with a team of researchers to analyze studies on lying from academics, police officers, and **psychologists**.

B. Two Items

The same is true when there are only two items joined by *and* or *but*. Note that when parallel structure involves infinitives (*to* + verb), it is not necessary to repeat the to after the first verb.

Incorrect: Deception expert Pamela Meyer has collaborated with a team of researchers to **survey** and **analyzing** existing studies on lying.

Correct: Deception expert Pamela Meyer has collaborated with a team of researchers to **survey** and **analyze** existing studies on lying.

C. Word Pairs

Certain pairs of words/phrases must always appear together.

- **(N)either…(n)or**
- **Not only…but (also)**
- **As…as**
- **More/less...than**

Incorrect: Unlike a train, a tram can run **either** on tracks **and** directly on the street.

Correct: Unlike a train, a tram can run **either** on tracks **or** directly on the street.

In addition, the constructions following the two sides of a word pair must match, i.e., be parallel.

Correct: In the 1920s, the music industry expanded rapidly, not only because of its **profitability (noun)** but also because of its strong **influence (noun)** on popular culture.

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14. MODIFICATION

A. Dangling Modifiers

When a descriptive phrase begins a sentence, the noun (subject) it describes must be placed immediately after the modifier. If it does not, a dangling modifier is created.

Incorrect: **Born in Mexico City in 1907**, **self-portraits** were what Frida Kahlo was best known for.

(Who was born in Mexico City in 1907? Frida Kahlo, not her self-portraits.)

Correct: **Born in Mexico City in 1907**, **Frida Kahlo** was best known for her self-portraits.

B. Misplaced Modifiers

Incorrect: The Great Wall of China was constructed was by thousands of **workers that originally consisted of separated military fortifications**.

(This implies that the workers originally consisted of fortifications.)

Correct: Originally consisting of separated military fortifications, **the Great Wall of China was constructed by thousands of workers**.

(This version makes clear that the Wall consisted of fortifications.) '

15. FAULTY COMPARISONS

Comparisons must be made between equivalent items: people must be compared to people (or other living creatures), and things must be compared to things.

On the SAT and ACT, comparisons can be tested in terms of both singular and plural nouns.

A. Singular Comparison

Incorrect: Though **the work (thing)** of architect Benjamin Marshall is just as well-known as **Frank Lloyd Wright (person)**, Marshall's name has largely been forgotten.

Correct: Though **the work (thing)** of architect Benjamin Marshall is just as well-known as **the work of (thing)** Frank Lloyd Wright, Marshall's name has largely been forgotten.

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Very often however, the phrases ***that of*** (sing.) and ***those of*** (pl.) replace nouns in correct answers.

Correct: Though **the work of (thing)** architect Benjamin Marshall is just as well-known as **that of (= the work of)** Frank Lloyd Wright, Marshall's name has largely been forgotten.

An apostrophe can also be used to create a possessive.

Correct: Though **the work of (thing)** architect Benjamin Marshall is just as well-known as **Frank Lloyd Wright's (= Frank Lloyd Wright's work)**, Marshall's name has largely been forgotten.

B. Plural Comparison

Incorrect: Often nicknamed the daddy longlegs, the harvestman has **limbs** that are nearly twice as long as **other spiders**.

Correct: Often nicknamed the daddy longlegs, the harvestman has **limbs** that are nearly twice as long as **those of (= the limbs of)** other spiders.

Correct: Often nicknamed the daddy longlegs, the harvestman has **limbs** that are nearly twice as long as **other spiders' (= other spiders' limbs)**.

C. Then vs. Than (ACT)

Use *than*, not *then*, to form comparisons.

Incorrect: The limbs of the harvestman spider are much longer then those of other spiders.

Correct: The limbs of the harvestman spider are much longer than those of other spiders.

D. "Quantity" Words

Number, *Many*, *Fewer* modify plural nouns.

Amount, *Much*, *Less* modify singular nouns.

E.g., *there were* ***fewer*** ***people***, NOT *there were* ***less*** ***people***.

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16. QUESTION MARKS

Question marks are tested rarely, but questions targeting them do appear occasionally.

Question marks are used only for direct questions—questions that are separate from the main body of a sentence.

Incorrect: Most of the experiments performed by cognitive psychologist Elizabeth Spelke have been designed to test one main question: **how much do babies and young children understand about the world around them.**

Correct: Most of the experiments performed by cognitive psychologist Elizabeth Spelke have been designed to test one main question: **how much do babies and young children understand about the world around them?**

When questions are asked indirectly—when they are integrated into a sentence—a period is used.

Incorrect: Most of the experiments performed by cognitive psychologist Elizabeth Spelke have been designed to test **how much babies and young children understand about the world around them?**

Correct: Most of the experiments performed by cognitive psychologist Elizabeth Spelke have been designed to test **how much babies and young children understand about the world around them.**

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ACT ONLY

17. SHORTER IS BETTER

Avoid wordiness and redundancy (repetition).

When multiple answers are grammatically correct and express the same essential information, the shortest one will virtually always be correct.

Note that many questions can be answered visually: you can start with the assumption that the shortest answer is correct and then check it out to be safe.

The construction of the Great Wall of China was an enormous undertaking

that occurred on a very large scale and required over 3,000 workers.

A. NO CHANGE
B. an enormously huge undertaking on a large scale
C. an enormous undertaking, which occurred on a very large scale
D. an enormous undertaking

The correct answer, D, can be determined with near certainty simply from its length. (This answer is right because an undertaking that occurs on a very large scale is by definition enormous. It is unnecessary to include both pieces of information.)

18. ADJECTIVES & ADVERBS

Adjectives modify nouns: the good book, the boring class, the exciting trip

Adverbs modify verbs and usually end in -ly: the girl ran quickly, the wind blew strongly

A. Adjectives and Adverbs Switched

Incorrect: Monkeys, a traditional Mexican symbol, appear **frequent** in Frida Kahlo's paintings.

Correct: Monkeys a traditional Mexican symbol, appear **frequently** in Frida Kahlo's paintings.

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B. Comparatives and Superlatives

Comparative – adjective + -er, or *more* + adjective (e.g., *better*, *stronger*, *more interesting*)

Superlative – adjective + -est, or *most* + adjective (e.g., *best*, *strongest*, *most interesting*)

- When *-er* is used, *more* should not also be used.
- When *–est* is used, *most* should not also be used.

Incorrect: Mexican folk art exerted a more stronger influence on Frida Kahlo's paintings than Surrealism did.

Correct: Mexican folk art exerted a stronger influence on Frida Kahlo's paintings than Surrealism did.

19. PRONOUN CASE

When pronoun case is tested, it will always be plural: usually proper name + pronoun (e.g., *Rob and me*) or two pronouns (e.g., *him and me*).

- **If name + pronoun, cross out the proper name and answer by ear.**
- **If two pronouns, cross out each pronoun in turn and answer by ear.**

Incorrect: Last year, my **mother and me** attended the Gathering of Nations, the largest annual meeting of Native Americans in the United States.

Cross out: Last year... **me** attended the Gathering of Nations, the largest annual meeting of Native Americans in the United States.

Because you would say "I attended," you would also say "my mother and I attended."

Correct: Last year, **my mother and I** attended the Gathering of Nations, the largest annual meeting of Native Americans in the United States.

Know: *between* should always be followed by an object pronoun (*me*, *her*, *him*, *them*, *us*).

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20. DICTIONS & IDIOMS

A. Could, should, would, might HAVE, not OF

Any answer choice that includes of rather than have can be automatically eliminated.

B. Prepositions and Verbs

Unfortunately, there is no rule for these questions; they must be answered by ear.

Incorrect: The Great Wall of China might have been more **effective with** keeping people in than keeping invaders out.

Correct: The Great Wall of China might have been more **effective at** keeping people in than keeping invaders out.

Incorrect: Some people claim that The Great Wall of China was really built to **capture** the Emperor's love of grandiose projects.

Correct: Some people claim that The Great Wall of China was really built to **satisfy** the Emperor's love of grandiose projects.

C. Register: Formal vs. Informal

Nearly all correct answers to these questions are, like ACT passage, not too formal or informal.

Incorrect: From the frigid lakes of the Himalayas to the tropical rain forests in the south, India's natural resources house **a whole bunch** of birds and animals. **(Too informal)**

Incorrect: From the frigid lakes of the Himalayas to the tropical rain forests in the south, India's natural resources house **a sublime plethora** of birds and animals. **(Too formal)**

Correct: From the frigid lakes of the Himalayas to the tropical rain forests in the south, India's natural resources house **a remarkable variety** of birds and animals. **(Just right)**

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Preposition-Based Idioms

Be curious about
Be particular about
Bring about
Complain about
Set (ab)out
Think about
Wonder about
Worry about

Known as/to be
Recognized as
Serve as
Translate as

Accompanied by
Amazed by
Assisted by
Awed by
Confused by
Encouraged by
Followed by
Impressed by
Obscured by
Outraged by
Perplexed by
Puzzled by
Shocked by
Stunned by
Surprised by

Celebrated for
Compensate for
Criticize for
Endure for
Famous for
Known for
Last for
Look (out) for

Named for/after
Necessary for
Prized for
Recognized for
Responsible for
Strive for
Wait for
Watch for

Across from
Apparent from
Defend from/against
Differ(ent) from
Protect from/against
Refrain from

In itself

Adept in/at
Confident in
Engage in/with
Firm in
Interested in
Involved in
Succeed in/at
Take pride in

Enter into
Insight into

A native of
Native to
Appreciation of
Aware of
Characteristic of
Consist of
Convinced of
Devoid of
(Dis)approve of
Family of

In recognition of
In the hope(s) of
(In)capable of
Knowledge of
Mastery of

Offer of
Principles of
Proponent of
Source of
Suspicious of
Take advantage of
Typical of
Understanding of
Use of

Based on
Confer on
Depend on
Draw (up)on
Dwell on
Focus on
Insist on
Reflect on
Rely on

Control over
Power over

Central to
Critical to
Devoted to

Explain to
Exposed to
In contrast to
Listen to
Native to
Point to
Prefer x to y
Recommend x to y

Relate to

Similar to
Threat(en) to
Unique to

Biased toward
Tendency toward

Take up

Contrast with
Correlate with
Identify with
(In)consistent with
(Pre)occupied with
Sympathize with
(Un)familiar with

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Globally, foods have become more alike and less diverse. As the amount of food around the world has shrunk to just a handful of crops, regional and local varieties have hit the road or even disappeared altogether.

A. NO CHANGE
B. taken a hike
C. disappeared
D. gotten out

A, B, and D are all far too informal and slangy. Only B is consistent with the prevailing tone of the passage.

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XVII. Transitions

Questions testing transitional words and phrases are generally more focused on meaning than on grammar. As a result, **answers that are grammatically acceptable may still be incorrect**.

Tip: whenever you encounter a transition question, **take your pencil and physically cross out the transition in the passage** so that you do not develop an unconscious bias toward that option. Then, state the relationship between the sentences/clauses (similar, different, cause-and-effect) **before** you look at the answer choices.

Incorrect: The obvious reason for the construction of the Great Wall of China was protection, and China had no powerful enemies at the time construction first began.

The two halves of the sentence express opposing ideas, so a contradictor is needed.

Correct: The obvious reason for the construction of the Great Wall of China was protection, but China had no powerful enemies at the time construction first began.

Important: if there is an OMIT/DELETE option, or an option that does not include a transition, check it **first** because it will usually be correct (at least on the ACT).

Also: when two transitions have the same meaning (e.g., *however* and *nevertheless*) and are grammatically acceptable in context, both can be eliminated because no question can have more than one right answer.

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Transitions

Continuers	Contradictors	Cause-and-Effect
And	(Al)though	Accordingly
	But	As a result
Also		As such
	Despite	Because
Finally	Even so	Consequently
Furthermore	Even though	For
In addition	However	
In conclusion		Hence
In fact Indeed	In contrast	Since
Likewise		
Moreover	In spite of	So
Next	Instead Meanwhile	Therefore
	Nevertheless	Thus
Of course	On the contrary	
Similarly	On the other hand	
Subsequently	Otherwise	
That is	Rather Regardless	
Then		
	Still	
	Whereas	
	While	
	Yet	

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